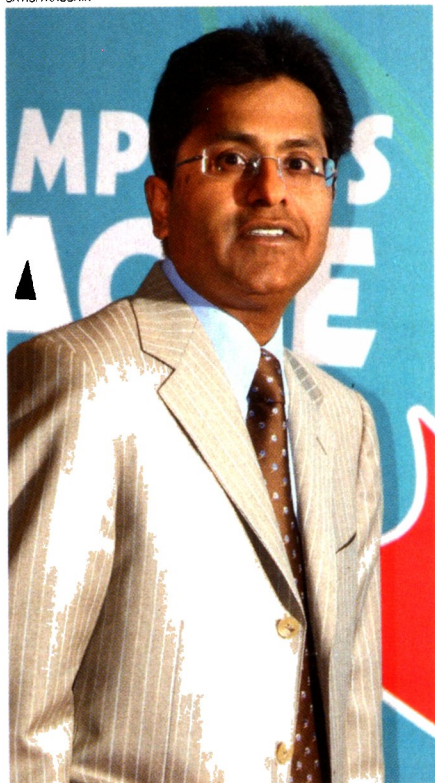


SATISH KAUSHIK



AP PHOTO

FROM (L TO R) MODI,
RAIN STOPS AN IPL
MATCH, SRINIVASAN

Undercover GAMES

The recent row over a contract between IPL and IMG is the result of the T20 event's overwhelming success and its essential lack of regulation. And it's a personal battle.

| By Sharda Ugra |

It is only an apocryphal story echoing off the walls of the BCCI's offices in Mumbai but it explains much. When BCCI Secretary N. Srinivasan was told that IPL Commissioner Lalit Modi had approved a particular decision, he snapped back, "Lalit doesn't run the BCCI, I do."

It will explain much to those scouring the newspaper to find out about Sachin Tendulkar's general well-being or the state of Virender Sehwag's shoulder but end up reading about a contractual dispute between the BCCI and the global management firm IMG.

This is a face-off at two levels: at the institutional level, where the BCCI's various state associations are demanding their share of the IPL pie and seeking to

trim down the popstar status accorded to Modi and his bounding baby.

The other is a more elemental war of egos between Modi, 45 and Srinivasan, 63, who, it is said, can barely bring themselves to speak to each other now.

Before the IMG row became public through a series of leaked correspondences, a difference between the two men over a plan to put the entire pool of IPL players through a re-auction at the end of three years, was simmering.

The re-auction would, naturally, stoke a buying frenzy and drive prices and valuations up, increasing the noise around the IPL. The IMG issue, insiders, say is merely a pretext, a round of shadow-boxing. The real tussle is a bitter personal (and political) feud for territory in Indian cricket between the

arriviste and the establishment man.

These legal tangles and personal clashes are the result of IPL's overwhelming success and its essential lack of regulation. IMG is only one example where a service provider was offered a commission-based contract (offered 10 per cent of gross IPL revenues) when all they did was organise logistics, not raise overall revenue.

Today, Srinivasan, the old-school BCCI mandarin, has ironically become a totem for the IPL's lack of regulation.

He wears three hats: two of these are BCCI secretary and IPL governing council member. Then, in a conflict of interest apparent, he is also franchise owner of the Chennai Super Kings (CSK) franchise through his company India Cements. CSK brand ambassador, Krishnamachari Srikkanth is also